

really good at their game and for us, competing ball for ball at their game may not be the right thing to do. We need to have a little bit more variety — more slices and coming up to the net a little more,” she said.

Hosting more tournaments at home can also help Indian players improve their rankings, as it gives them the advantage of being familiar with local conditions and removes the financial burden of travelling abroad.

Tough conditions

The playing conditions during the tournament weren't as brutal as the peak Chennai summer, but after spending two days in their hotel rooms due to rain, several players struggled with the heat and humidity. The first round witnessed three retirements due to illness, while Vekic had to have blood samples taken and her vitals checked after feeling dizzy during her match against Vaishnavi.

Later, Chinese Taipei's Joanna Garland suffered from cramps and breathing issues during her 6-7(2), 6-3, 7-5 loss to Birrell in the semifinal, which was also the longest match of the event at three hours and 24 minutes. The 27-year-old Australian, who had eliminated Vekic in the previous round, came from 0-5 down in the decider and saved four match points to reach her second Tour-level final, following her runner-up finish at last year's Japan Open.

In the other semifinal, fourth-seeded Indonesian Janice Tjen (**above**) survived a tough challenge from talented Thai player Lanlana Tararudee, winning 7-6(6), 7-6(5). Like Birrell, Tjen progressed to her second Tour-level final (she was runner-up at the Sao Paulo Open in September).

Tjen beat Birrell 6-4, 6-3 in two hours in front of around 1,000 spectators at the SDAT Stadium — the highest turnout of the week — becoming the first Indonesian champion at this level since Angelique Widjaja's 2002 triumph in Pattaya City.

Tjen, whose game is heavily influenced by former World No. 1 Ash Barty, uses a lot of backhand slices and drop shots alongside a potent forehand. She also won the doubles title with compatriot Aldila Sutjiadi, as the second seeds defeated the

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top-seeded Australian-Romanian duo of Storm Hunter and Monica Niculescu 7-5, 6-4.

It has been an outstanding season for the 23-year-old Tjen. She has clinched six ITF titles, one WTA 125 trophy and now a Tour-level title, and also became the first Indonesian woman in more than two decades to win a Grand Slam match during the U.S. Open. At the start of the year, she was outside the Top 400 in the WTA Rankings. On Monday, she achieved a new career high of World No. 53.

Tournament's future

The tournament returned to Chennai this year after TNTA President Vijay Amritraj coordinated with Octagon — the sports agency holding the three-year licence for the event — to relocate it from Mexico. However, the only available slot was last week, clashing with two other WTA 250s in Hong Kong and Jiangxi.

According to next year's calendar, the event is scheduled to be held in Chennai again from November 2-8, the final week of the 2026 season before the WTA Finals in Riyadh. A call on whether it will remain in Chennai will be taken soon. “We will make a decision regarding the tournament's future by the end of this year and take WTA's approval,” Alastair Garland, managing director of the tennis division of Octagon, told *Sportstar*.

Honour board



Singles

Winner: Janice Tjen (Indonesia)
Ranking points: 250
Prize money: INR 31.58 lakh

Runner-up: Kimberly Birrell (Australia)
Ranking points: 163
Prize money: INR 18.69 lakh

Best result by Indians:
Shrivalli Bhamidipaty, Sahaja Yamalapalli (Round of 16)
Ranking points: 30
Prize money: INR 3.62 lakh

Doubles

Winner: Janice Tjen (Indonesia) and Aldila Sutjiadi (Indonesia)
Ranking points: 250
Prize money: INR 11.48 lakh

Runner-up: Storm Hunter (Australia) and Monica Niculescu (Romania)
Ranking points: 163
Prize money: INR 6.46 lakh

Best result by Indians:
Rutuja Bhosale and Riya Bhatia (semifinalists)
Ranking points: 98
Prize money: INR 3.71 lakh